Lexical Variation in the Understanding of ברא: Homonymy or Polysemy?

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The Problem

Gen 1:1 (Qal)

בְּרֵאשִׁית בָּרָא אֱלֹהִים אֵת הַשָּׁמַיִם וְאֵת הָאָרֶץ

In the beginning when God created the heavens and the earth.

Ezek 23:47a (Piel)

וְרָגְמוּ עֲלֵיהֶן אֶבֶן קָהָל וּבָרֵא אוֹתָהֶן בְּחַרְבוֹתָם

The assembly shall stone them and with their swords they shall cut them down.

1 Sam 2:29 (Hiphil)

לָמָּה תִבְעֲטוּ בְּזִבְחִי וּבְמִנְחָתִי אֲשֶׁר צִוִּיתִי מָעוֹן וַתְּכַבֵּד אֶת־בָּנֶיךָ מִמֶּנִּי לְהַבְרִיאַכֶם מֵרֵאשִׁית כָּל־מִנְחַת יִשְׂרָאֵל לְעַמִּי

Why then look with greedy eye at my sacrifices and my offerings that I commanded, and honor your sons more than me by fattening yourselves on the choicest parts of every offering of my people Israel?

Distribution of Verbal Stems (ברא)

Qal (38)
Gen. 1:1, 21, 27; 2:3; 5:1, 2; 6:7
Num. 16:30
Deut. 4:32
Is. 4:5; 40:26, 28; 41:20; 42:5; 43:1, 7, 15; 45:7, 8, 12, 18; 54:16; 57:19; 65:17, 18
Jer. 31:22
Amos 4:13
Mal. 2:10
Psa. 51:12; 89:13, 48
Eccl. 12:1

Niphal (10)
Gen. 2:4; 5:2
Ex. 34:10
Is. 48:7
Ezek. 21:35; 28:13, 15
Psa. 102:19; 104:30; 148:5

Piel (5)
Josh. 17:15, 18
Ezek. 21:24; 23:47

Hiphil (1)
1 Sam. 2:29

Implications

Ibn Ezra: ". . . in accordance with its etymology: to limit, to define, by drawing or incising a line or boundary."

Bill T. Arnold, *New Cambridge Bible Commentary: Genesis*, 2009: "it seems likely that the verb *bārā'* has developed from 'separate by cutting' (the supposed *bārā'* III), and that it has here an intentional, and no less theologically significant connotation of creating by cutting, shaping, or fashioning. . . . God masterfully divides the cosmos by a series of 'cuts' and differentiates its components into 'kinds.'"

Recent Debate

- 2009, E. J. van Wolde.
  - oברא—to separate; to differentiate.
    - Underlying meaning in both Qal and Piel.
- 2010, Bob Becking and Marjo C.A. Korpel.
  - oברא—to build/construct.
  - To cut (Piel) is entirely unrelated.
- 2011, E. J. van Wolde and Robert Rezetko.
  - Counter Becking and Korpel's points, primarily using etymology.
- 2014, Terrance Randall Wardlaw .
  - “To create (something new)” as an extension of the concrete Piel "to cut."
  - Creation occurs by cutting or sculpture.

Remapping the Problem (Identifying the Question)

- "The treatment of homonyms has been perhaps the most variable and inconsistent aspect of Hebrew lexicography." David J.A. Clines
- Key terms:
  - Homonym.
  - Polyseme.

Understanding Homonymy

- **True homonym:** simultaneous homophone and homograph. Different origin.
  - Arm—defensive and offensive outfit for war, things used in fighting.
    - Etymology: French *armes*, Latin *arma* (no singular).
  - Arm—the upper limb of the human body.
    - Etymology: Common Germanic. Old Germanic **armoz*, cognate with Latin *armus*.

Understanding Polysemy

Polyseme: shared etymology.

Pupil—A person who is being taught by another. Older definition: an orphan or child.

Etymology: Anglo-Norman and Middle French *pupille*, classical Latin *pūpillus*.

Pupil—The opening in the iris through which light passes into the eye.

Etymology: Transferred use of classical Latin *pūpilla* (female child), so called on account of the small reflected image seen when looking into someone's pupil.

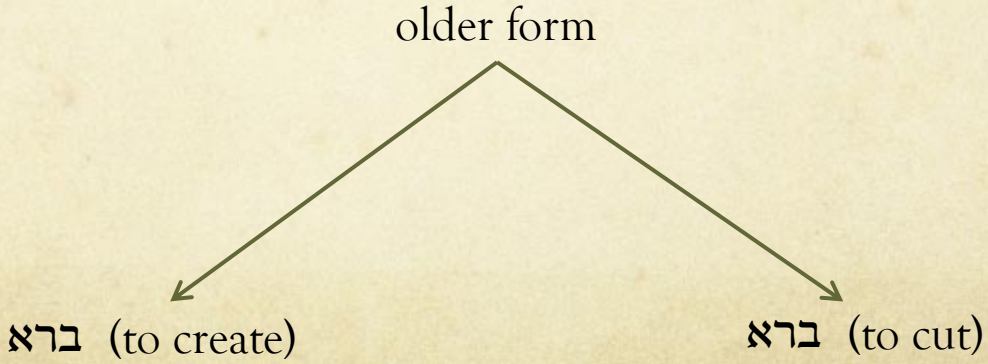
Equivalent occurrence in Greek κόρη—pupil of the eye; girl, maiden.

Underlying Possibilities

If homonyms:



If polysemes:



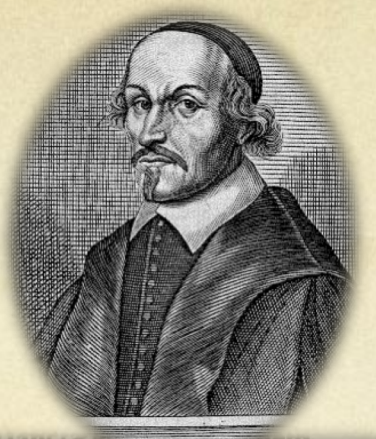
The Lexica

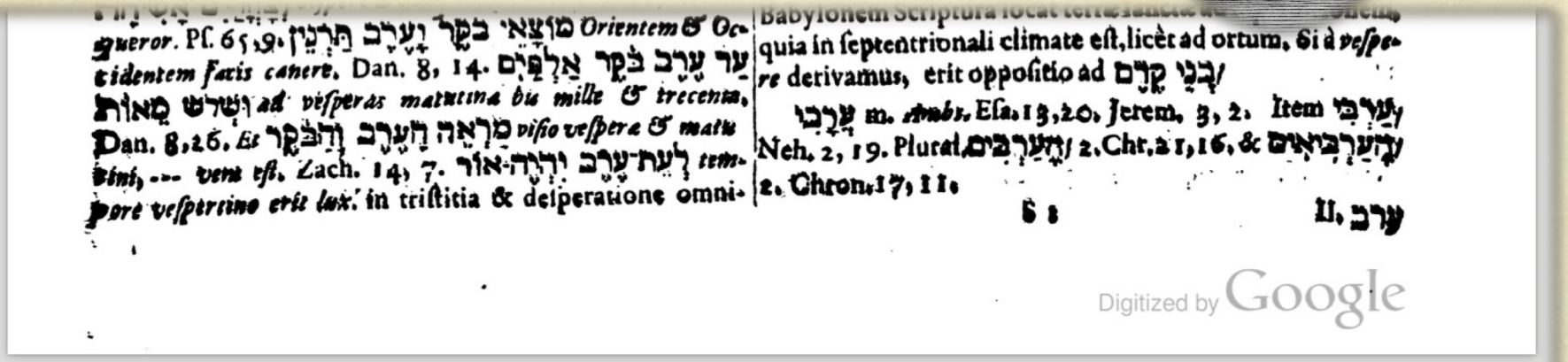
"I will offer an axiom: most dictionaries are copies of other dictionaries. Just as well, you might say, since a dictionary that had only original meanings would be useless. The downside, though, is that the mistakes and myopia of the past tend to be perpetuated, and that means for over 500 years in some cases."

David J.A. Clines, *Towards a Science of Comparative Classical Hebrew Lexicography*

Johannes Cocceius

Lexicon et commentarius sermonis hebraici et chaldaici, 1714.





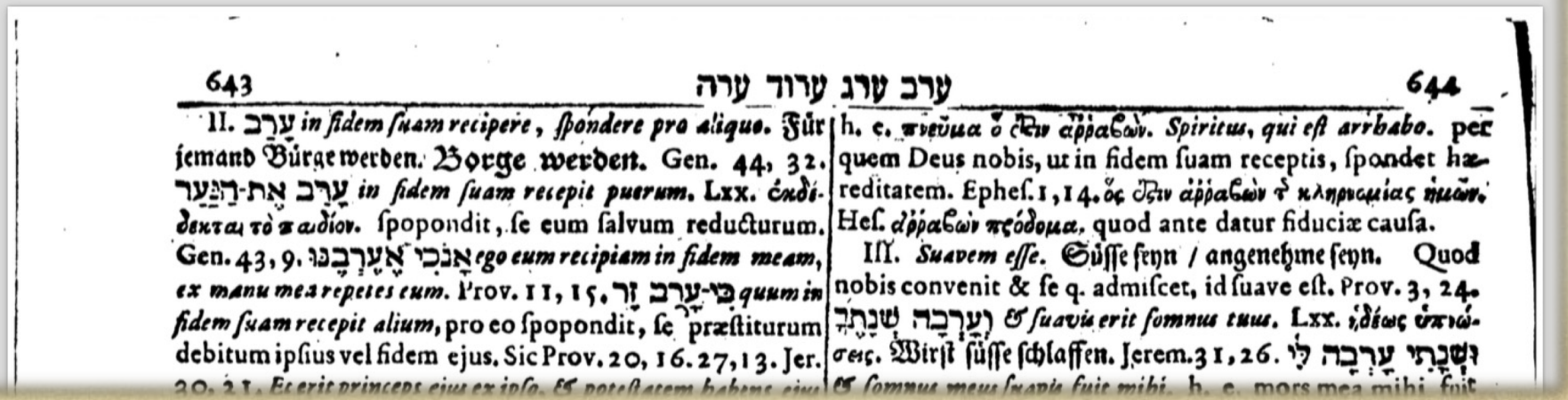
מוֹצָאֵי בֹקֶר וָעֶרֶב תַּרַנֵּן *Orientem & Occidentem facis canere.* Dan. 8, 14. עַד עֶרֶב בֹּקֶר אַלְפַּיִם *ad vesperas matutina bis mille & trecenta,* וְשֶׁלֶשׁ מֵאוֹת Dan. 8, 26. *Et* מַרְאֵה הָעֶרֶב וְהַבֹּקֶר *visio vespere & matutini, — vera eſt.* Zach. 14, 7. לְעֵת-עֶרֶב יִהְיֶה-אוֹר *tempore veſpertino erit lux.* in triſtitia & deſperatione omni-

Babylonem Scriptura locat terræ ſanctæ ſitæ, quia in ſeptentrionali climate eſt, licèt ad ortum. Si à *veſpere* derivamus, erit oppoſitio ad בְּנֵי קֶדֶם/

עַרְבִי m. *Arabs.* Eſa. 13, 20. Jerem. 3, 2. Item עֲרָבִי Neh. 2, 19. Plural עֲרָבִים/ עֲרַבִיאִים 2. Chr. 21, 16. & 2. Chron. 17, 11.

II. ערב

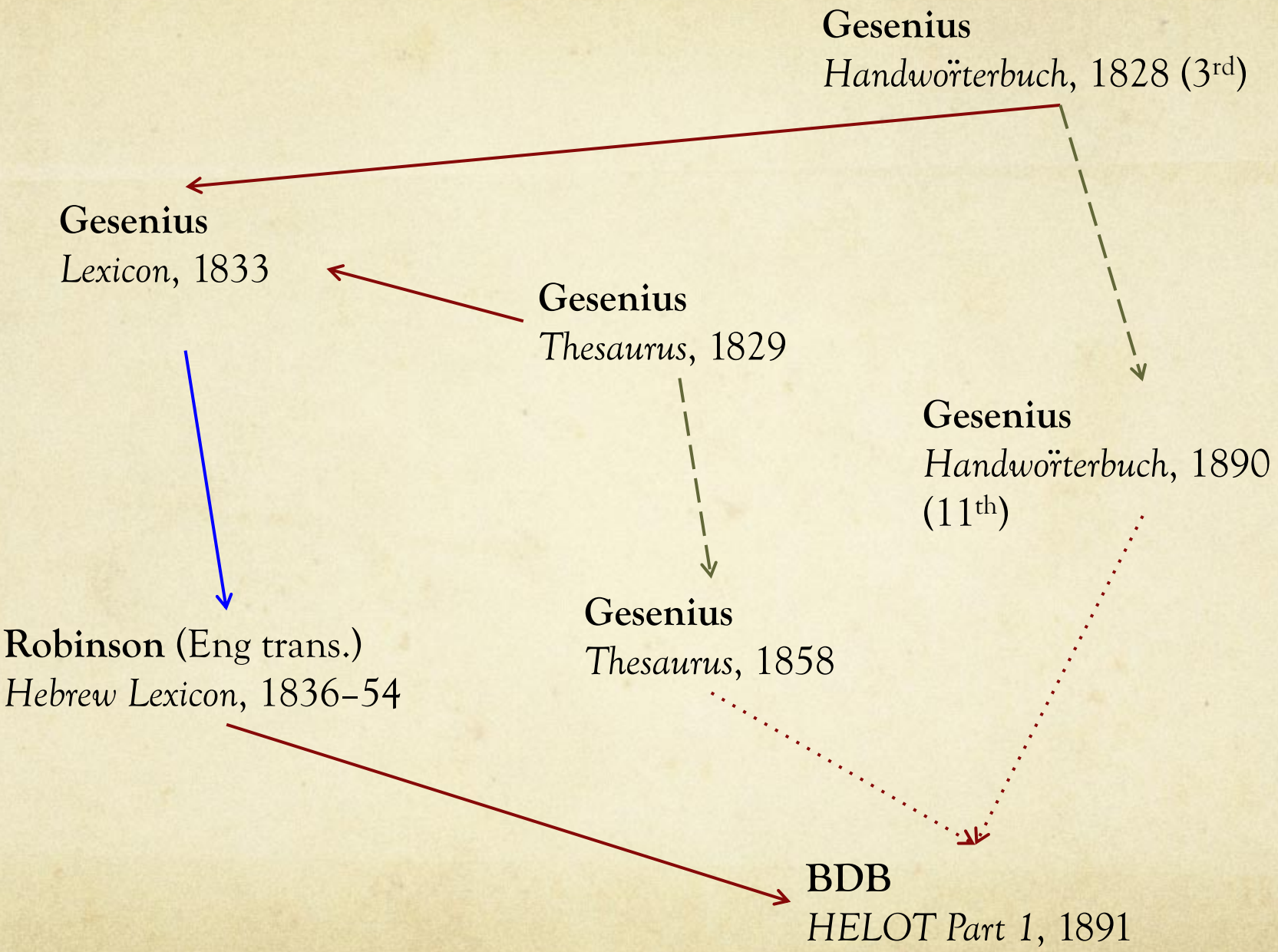
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II. עָרַב *in fidem ſuam recipere, ſpondere pro aliquo.* Für jemand Bürge werden. Borge werden. Gen. 44, 32. עָרַב אֶת-הַנַּעַר *in fidem ſuam recepit puerum.* Lxx. ἐκδέκται τὸ παιδίον. ſpopondit, ſe eum ſalvum reducturum. Gen. 43, 9. אָנֹכִי אֶעֶרְבֶנּוּ *ego eum recipiam in fidem meam, ex manu mea repetes eum.* Prov. 11, 15. זֹר-עָרַב *quum in fidem ſuam recepit alium,* pro eo ſpopondit, ſe præſtiturum debitum ipſius vel fidem ejus. Sic Prov. 20, 16. 27, 13. Jer. 30, 21. *Et erit princeps eius ex ipſo, & poteſtatem habens eius*

h. e. πνεῦμα ὃ ἔδωκεν ἀρραβῶνα. *Spiritus, qui eſt arrhabo.* per quem Deus nobis, ut in fidem ſuam receptis, ſpondet hæreditatem. Epheſ. 1, 14. ὅς ἐστιν ἀρραβὼν τῆς κληρονομίας ἡμῶν. Heſ. ἀρραβῶν πρόδομα, quod ante datur fiduciæ cauſa.

III. *Suavem eſſe.* Süſſe ſeyn / angenehme ſeyn. Quod nobis convenit & ſe q. admiſcet, id ſuave eſt. Prov. 3, 24. וְעָרְבָה שְׁנָתֶךָ *& ſuavis erit ſomnus tuus.* Lxx. ἡδέως ὑπνώσεις. Wirſt ſüſſe ſchlaffen. Jerem. 31, 26. וְשְׁנָתִי עָרְבָה לִי *& ſomnus meus ſuavis fuit mihi,* h. e. mors mea mihi fuit


Gesenius
Handwörterbuch, 1828 (3rd)
Gesenius
Lexicon, 1833
Gesenius
Thesaurus, 1829
Gesenius
Handwörterbuch, 1890
(11th)
Gesenius
Thesaurus, 1858
Robinson (Eng trans.)
Hebrew Lexicon, 1836–54
BDB
HELOT Part 1, 1891

First Model

BDB, 1891

1 ברא

Qal—*shape, fashion, create.*

Niphal—*be created.*

Piel—*cut down, cut out.*

2 ברא

Hiphil—*be fat.*

Frants Buhl

Handwörterbuch, 1895 (12th)



I. **ברא** arab. بَرَأَ, aram. בְּרָא (sab. ברא bed. bauen). Vgl. über das Alter des Wortes Wellh. Proll. 411, ZAW 1,247, Dillm. zu Gn 1, 1.

Kal perf. בָּרָא, *impf.* יִבְרָא, *imp.* בְּרָא, *inf.* בְּרֹא, *part.* בֹּרֵא (nur Jes 45, 7), בּוֹרֵא m. *Suff.* בֹּרְאֶךָ — 1) schaffen, hervorbringen und zwar nur vom göttlichen Schaffen, nirgends m. d. Acc. des Stoffes. So vom Hervorbringen des Himmels und der Erde Gn 1, 1, der Menschen 1,27. 5,1.2 (u. oft bei P); 6,7 (bei J) und anderer Naturgegenstände Jes 4, 5. 40, 28. Am 4, 13. Jes 45, 7, aber auch der Zustände in der moralischen Welt Jes 45, 7 (2tes Glied). Ps 51, 12. Jer 31, 22: *Gott schafft etwas Neues im*

Lande: das Weib wird den Mann schirmen. Mit dopp. Accus. Jes 65, 18: הִנְנִי בוֹרֵא אֶת־יְרוּשָׁלַיִם גִּילָה *siehe, ich will Jerusalem in Frohlocken umschaffen* (das Wort kommt überhaupt 20 mal bei Deuterojes. vor). Mit עָשָׂה wird es öfter synonym gebraucht, s. Gn 1, 26. 27. 2, 4; dass jedoch ein Unterschied zw. beiden war, ergibt sich aus 2, 3: אֲשֶׁר־בָּרָא אֱלֹהִים לַעֲשׂוֹת *welches Gott schöpferisch gemacht hatte.* בָּרָא bed. näml. neu hervorbringen und die Konstr. ist wie הִגְדִּיל לַעֲשׂוֹת; s. Dillmann z. d. St.

Niph. 2. *f.* נִבְרֵאת, *pl.* נִבְרְאוּ, *impf. i. p.* יִבָּרְאוּן, *inf.* m. *Suff.* הִבָּרְאָךְ, *part.* נִבְרָא — geschaffen werden Gn 2, 4. 5, 2. Ps 148, 5 hervorgebracht werden Ez 21, 35: בְּמָקוֹם אֲשֶׁר־נִבְרֵאת *an dem Orte, wo du in das Dasein getreten bist,* 28, 13. 15. Ps 104, 30. Ps 102, 19: וְעַם נִבְרָא יְהַלֶּל־יָהּ *das Volk, das geschaffen wird, preise Jahve.* Von den Wunderthaten Gottes Ex 34, 10. Jes 48, 7.†

Deriv. בְּרִיאָה vgl. בְּרִיָּה.

II. **ברא** vgl. d. ass. *Ištafal šutabrû,* sich sättigen, מרא III (s. d.), بَرِئَ sehr fest sein und ברה I. Vgl. Grill ZAW 8, 275.

Hiph. inf. m. *Suff.* לְהַבְרִיאֲכֶם, fett machen, mästen 1 S 2, 29.†

Derivat: בְּרִיא.

III. **ברא** vgl. בַּר IV.

Pi. 3. *ps. cons.* וּבֵרַאתָ, *m. S.* וּבֵרַאתוֹ, *inf. abs.* בָּרֹא, abholzen, den Wald lichten, roden, mit *acc.* Jos 17, 15. 18; übertr. zerhauen, Ez 23, 47.† — Für das dopp. בָּרֵא Ez 21, 24 liest Corn. das zweite Mal בָּרֹאשׁ und streicht das erste.

Two Paradigms

BDB, 1891

1 ברא

- Qal—*shape, fashion, create*
- Niphal—*be created*
- Piel—*cut down, cut out*

2 ברא

- Hiphil—*be fat*

Gesenius-Buhl, 1895

1 ברא

Qal—*schaffen, hervorbringen*

Niphal—*geschaffen werden*

2 ברא

Hiphil—*fett machen, mästen*

3 ברא

Piel—*abholzen, den Wald lichten, roden*

Koehler-Baumgartner

Ludwig Koehler, *Lexicon in Veteris Testamenti libros. A Dictionary of the Hebrew Old Testament in English and German*, 1948–1953.

Koehler and Baumgartner, *Hebraïsches und aramaïsches Lexicon zum Alten Testament [HALAT]*, 1967–1995, 5 vols.

> Translated by M.E.J. Richardson, *The Hebrew and Aramaic Lexicon of the Old [HALOT]*, 1994–2000.

Following Gesenius-Buhl

KB (HALOT), 1967

- ברא I
  - Qal
  - Niphal
- ברא II
  - Hiphil
- ברא III
  - Piel
- ברא IV
  - 2 Sam 12:17 > ברה I.

DCH, 1993

- ברא I
  - Qal
  - Niphal
- ברא II
  - Hiphil
  - Niphal (conj.)
- ברא III
  - Piel
- ברא IV
  - 2 Eat, see ברה I.

Two Paradigms

Qal and Piel as Polysemes

ברא 1

Qal—*shape, fashion, create*

Niphal—*be created*

Piel—*cut down, cut out*

ברא 2

Hiphil—*be fat*

Qal and Piel as Homonyms

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Qal—*schaffen, hervorbringen*

Niphal—*geschaffen werden*

ברא 2

Hiphil—*fett machen, mästen*

ברא 3

Piel—*abholzen, den Wald lichten, roden*